

Board of Trustees Meeting Minutes

Wednesday, February 25, 2026

5:30 p.m. via Zoom

Administrative Service Center
415 Tumwater Blvd SW
Tumwater, WA 98501

Brian Mittge, *President*, Lewis County
Dustin Loup, *President Elect*, Grays Harbor County
Mary Beth Harrington, Thurston County
Toni Gwin, Pacific County
Hal Blanton, *At-Large*, Lewis County
Vacant Position, Mason County
Vacant Position, *At-Large*, Thurston County

Present Board: Brian Mittge, Dustin Loup, Mary Beth Harrington, Toni Gwin, Hal Blanton

Present Staff: Cheryl Heywood, Andrea Heisel, Brenda Lane, Paige Preston, Kandy Seldin, Rose Enos-Weedmark; recorder

Remote Access: Zoom: <https://Trl-org.zoom.us/j/88278787744> • Meeting ID: 882 7878 7744 • Phone Access (253) 215-8782 • Approximate Attendance = 235

Timberland Regional Library (TRL) Business Meeting Minutes

- 1. CALL TO ORDER AND ROLL CALL** – Brian Mittge called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m.
- 2. PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE** – Toni Gwin led the pledge
- 3. OPENING BOARD COMMENTS – at 2:06 of the recording** Trustee Mittge explains that we will be reviewing budgetary concerns and addressing adjustments. Mittge states that the bottom line is that our expenses have increased faster than our revenue. Overtime TRL has leaned into technology to help with workflows to save money. TRL has reduced hours at some locations and one location is utilizing Expanded Access Hours (EAH) solely, which has key card access that can be used at other EAH locations. Mittge adds that even with the cost saving measures throughout the years, it has led to the recent budget shortfall when the final 2025 numbers came back lower than expected causing TRL to come under the policy requirements, 30% of expected revenues. Immediate measures are required to restore the 30%, which will include cost cutting measures such as buying fewer books, freezing all new hires, stopping all non-essential purchases, and laying off staff. We know they are our colleagues, neighbors, and friends. It is a hard situation, but TRL must be fiscally responsible for the 550k patrons it serves in our five-county district. Mittge concludes that TRL is annually audited by the state auditor and our staff manage the financial books with integrity and honesty. The money did not disappear, TRL spent the money to keep things going. We want to keep libraries open and this plan will do that to the best of our abilities. Trustee Blanton shares that the trustees take their roles seriously and diligently working through this and we appreciate patron letters. Trustee Loup states that we all share a love of libraries and how they have impacted our lives. Loup thanks all of the staff and especially the frontline staff. There were many decisions over the years that have gotten us to this point and this is difficult for all of us. This is a hard process and any action we take will be out of necessity and not taken lightly. Trustee Gwin concurs with the other Trustees and thanks patrons for some thoughtful ideas moving forward. Gwin shares that Naselle was a dying library by all of the statistics for a branch. In the time it went to full EAH to now, library cards have doubled. Gwin shares her concern for the challenging decisions ahead. Trustee Harrington shares that layoffs are not what Administration or the Board want. Harrington shares that every current Board member has a wealth of knowledge and experience that they bring to TRL, with every decision made with care. Harrington shares her full support to TRL Administration.

4. CORRESPONDENCE – at 21:05 of the recording Rose Enos-Weedmark, Executive Administrator, shares one email from Darleen Adkins, off topic. There were 123 written public comments regarding the TRL budget.

5. PUBLIC COMMENTS – at 21:30 of the recording the following individuals made a verbal public comment regarding the budget: Savannah Campbell Harris, Scott Williams, Skyler Walker, Ari Greene, Jason Tippner, Ruch McConnell, Kylie McQuarrie, Rebecca Durr, Rachelle Martin, Hillary Tully, Lee Riner, Breanda Goates, Victoria Loveland, Michael Rainey, Calvin Parker, Mary Prophit, Stephanie Langner, David Webb, Paige Wright, Sako Chapman, Suzanne Beatty, Richard Rubio, Akasha Atherton, Mary Boone, Robert Vanderpool, Margaret Taft, Rachel Burk, Jack Jay, Kenny Farver, Sue Holt, Caleb Gieger, and Emily Clouse.

6. APPROVAL OF AGENDA – at 1:51:25 of the recording

26-011 – HAL BLANTON MADE A MOTION TO APPROVE THE AMENDED AGENDA TO INCLUDE A TEN (10) MINUTE BREAK AND A FIFTY (50) MINUTE CLOSED SESSION AFTER. TONI GWIN SECONDED. MOTION APPROVED (Unanimous 5).

7. TEN (10) MINUTE BREAK – at 1:54:46 or 7:25 p.m. to 7:35 p.m.

8. CLOSED SESSION pursuant to *RCW 42.30.140 4(b)* – **at 1:54:56 of the recording**

The Board of Trustees, Cheryl Heywood, Andrea Heisel, Brenda Lane, Paige Preston, and Kandy Seldon went into the closed session at 7:35 p.m. for 50 minutes.

At 8:24 p.m., Brian Mittge announced the closed session requested another 20 minutes.

Everyone returned to the main session at 8:46 p.m.

9. APPROVAL OF THE CONSENT AGENDA ITEMS – at 1:55:52 of the recording

26-012 – MARY BETH HARRINGTON MADE A MOTION TO APPROVE THE CONSENT AGENDA AS PRESENTED. TONI GWIN SECONDED. MOTION APPROVED (Unanimous 5).

10. EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR– at 1:56:17 of the recording Cheryl shares that this is a challenging moment in TRL’s history. We are facing an immediate budget shortfall through to the end of the year. Living within the 1% has made us improve and streamline internal operations and make the most of our funds, we have continually done more with less.

11. FINANCIAL STATEMENTS & HIGHLIGHTS – at 1:58:45 of the recording Cheryl highlights the month ending January 31, 2026:

- **General Fund** - \$101,177.41 in property taxes was received; Timber revenue - \$56,413.45 was received; and \$119,601.97 in books and materials was purchased.
- **Technology Fund** – Had minimal activity.
- **Unemployment Fund** – Had minimal activity.
- **Gift Fund** – Had minimal activity.
- **Building Fund** – Had minimal activity.

A. Budget Adjustment Resolution

26-013 – MARY BETH HARRINGTON MOTION TO APPROVE RESOLUTION 26-001 AMENDING THE 2026 BUDGET AS PRESENTED. TONI GWIN SECONDED. MOTION APPROVED (Unanimous 5).

B. Reduction in Force

26-014 – DUSTIN LOUP MOTION TO MOVE THAT THE TIMBERLAND REGIONAL LIBRARY BOARD OF TRUSTEES APPROVE THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE REDUCTION IN FORCE (RIF) AS DISCUSSED FOR THE PURPOSE OF ENSURING FINANCIAL SUSTAINABILITY FOR THE REMAINDER OF THE 2026 FISCAL YEAR AND AUTHORIZE THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR TO TAKE ALL NECESSARY ACTIONS TO IMPLEMENT THE REDUCTION IN FORCE

(RIF) IN ACCORDANCE WITH APPLICABLE POLICIES, PROCEDURES AND LEGAL REQUIREMENTS. MARY BETH HARRINGTON SECONDED. MOTION APPROVED (Unanimous 5).

12. FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS – None

13. BOARD HOUSEKEEPING – None

14. FINAL BOARD COMMENTS – at 2:09:42 of the recording Trustee Gwin thanks the audience and invites them to join the continuing saga at the next Board meeting. Trustee Mittge also thanks everyone for attending and staying until the end. Trustee Loup adds that staff impacted by the RIF, your work has been appreciated.

26-015 – MARY BETH HARRINGTON MOTION TO ADJOURN. DUSTIN LOUP SECONDED. MOTION APPROVED (Unanimous 5).

15. ADJOURNMENT at 9:02 p.m.